to spell out the goals, identify the challenges and suggest implementation strategies. This resulted in the evolution of a document titled, 'Peace, Progress and Prosperity in the Northeastern Region: Vision 2020'. At an NEC plenary session at Agartala on 13 May 2008, all the governors and chief ministers became signatories to this important document, and it was formally released by the prime minister on 2 July 2008 in New Delhi.

> India's Look East Policy is not only an external economic policy, it is also a strategic shift in India's vision in the world and India's place in the evolving global economy. Most of all it is about reaching out to our civilizational neighbours in Southeast Asia and East Asia.
>
> – Prime Minister Manmohan Singh.[1]

Although the results of this policy have not yet manifested themselves in the northeastern states, there is huge potential of boosting the economy of this region by linking it to Southeast Asia through surface trade routes. Thus, the answer lies in encouraging Indian investment in infrastructure in neighbouring countries, and resolving outstanding issues of investment, trade and transit. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's government deserves to be complimented for giving a boost to our Look East policy. His visit in October 2010 to Malaysia, Vietnam and Japan is a pointer to India's increasing engagement with Southeast and East Asia. Analysts who see this as encirclement of China are looking at it in an unreal and sensational manner. India needs to open up with its eastern neighbours for the economic benefits that would accrue to people in our northeast. No doubt this initiative also has its ramifications on the political and security domains. An encouraging development is the expression of intent by the ASEAN to jointly fight terrorism and transnational crime.

With a highway connecting Kolkata-Dhaka-Guwahati-Myitkyina-Mandalay-Kunming-Hanoi or going to Laos, Thailand and Singapore, the whole economic profile of the region would get transformed. Having seen the benefits of the 160-kilometre Tamu-Kaleywa (India-Myanmar) friendship highway to Mandalay, we need to focus on the